
**Unit 1, Option C,
Topic C6: Britain
and the Scramble
for Africa, c1875-
1914**

The focus of this topic is on the remarkable British imperial expansion in Africa in the last quarter of the 19th century and years before the First World War. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four content bullet points offer a framework for understanding the themes of the exercise of imperial power and the challenges and resistance to that power. Bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, a question on the popular response to Empire would draw on bullet point 3 (the Second Boer War) and the last bullet point, which explicitly deals with this issue.

The first bullet point relates to the almost accidental acquisition of British primacy and imperial control in Egypt between 1875 and 1885. Students should understand the importance to Britain of the Suez Canal and the reasons for Disraeli's purchase of the Khedive's shares in 1875. They should understand the reasons for Gladstone's decision for military intervention in Egypt in 1882 and the attempts to conceal and/or limit formal control through the setting up of the International Debt Commission and declared intention to withdraw. They should recognise the significance of Gordon's expedition to the Sudan in 1884-85 and the tensions created for governments of 'imperial pull' to ever greater involvement and expansion.

The second bullet point relates to expansion of formal control in these years and the reasons for this expansion. Students should understand the reasons for, and the nature of, the extension of control along the Nile Valley and within east Africa, involving Kenya and Zanzibar (to 1890), Uganda (1894) and the Sudan (1896-98), the consolidation and expansion from existing bases in west Africa, and the extension of British power in southern Africa at the expense of the Zulus in 1879. Students should understand the significance of the Berlin Conference of 1884-85 in the partition of west Africa and the arrangements made with Germany in 1886 and 1890 with regard to east Africa and with France in 1898 and 1904 regarding west and north Africa.

The third bullet point relates to the rather special circumstances in South Africa and the conflicts that developed between the British Empire and the Boer republics of the Transvaal and Orange Free State. Students should understand the reasons for the outbreak of conflict, first in 1880 and then more seriously in 1899. Although questions will not be set on particular campaigns, students should understand and be able to illustrate why the conflict of this Second Boer War was so lengthy and expensive. They should understand the aftermath in terms of both the immediate Peace of Vereeniging and the later establishment of the Union of South Africa.